



CNN's guide to the most important elections of 2026

Washington —

This year's midterms will not only shape the final two years of Donald Trump's presidency; they'll determine what politics after Trump might start to look like.

A series of races that starts with primaries on March 3 will either preserve Republican majorities in Congress, helping Trump to push through his agenda, or give Democrats control of either the US House or Senate and the ability to stop his legislative priorities and open investigations into him.

Along the way, candidates and party leaders will dissect the results as they prepare for the 2028 presidential race, which will be the first national election in 16 years without Trump's name on the ballot.

Here are the key dates and contests they – and we – will be watching over the course of the next year:

March 3: Texas and North Carolina

Texas is home to blockbuster Senate primaries on both sides that will tee up one of the year's most high-profile contests – a race that is poised to offer clues about the types of candidates voters are looking to lead their parties –

where tone and tactics might shape the outcomes more than policy proposals or ideology.

Incumbent GOP Sen. John Cornyn is being **challenged** by state Attorney General Ken Paxton and Rep. Wesley Hunt. The Democratic contest features **Rep. Jasmine Crockett** and **state Rep. James Talarico**. Democrats will also choose a nominee for governor to run against incumbent GOP Gov. Greg Abbott, who is seeking a fourth term.

There's seemingly less drama in the outcome of the Senate primaries in North Carolina, where former **Democratic Gov. Roy Cooper** and **former RNC chair Michael Whatley** appear headed toward a key general election clash.

March 17: Illinois

Illinois Sen. Dick Durbin's **retirement** has sparked a crowded field of Democrats seeking to replace the veteran lawmaker. Among the top contenders: Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton, who is backed by Gov. JB Pritzker, and a pair of Chicago-area House members, Reps. Robin Kelly and Raja Krishnamoorthi.

April 21: Virginia redistricting

There aren't any candidates on the ballot here – but the outcome of the redistricting referendum in Virginia could have far-reaching implications for the battle for control of Congress. Voters will decide whether to redraw the state's congressional map to give Democrats a chance at gaining as

many as four US House seats. That could result in a 10-1 split in Virginia's US House delegation in favor of Democrats, who currently hold a 6-5 edge. Given the narrow margin in the House, those four seats could be critical to Democrats' hopes of winning the majority – or the GOP's hopes of retaining control of the chamber – leading both parties to invest significant resources and lean on high-profile figures to help their cause.

May 5: Ohio

The Ohio Senate race is effectively set, with GOP Sen. Jon Husted and former Democratic Sen. Sherrod Brown on a collision course for the November general election. Ohio has shifted from a perennial battleground to a reliably red state, but Brown is key to **Democrats' hopes** of flipping the Senate.

The Buckeye State also has an open contest for governor with GOP Gov. Mike DeWine ineligible to run again because of term limits. On the Republican side, former 2024 presidential candidate Vivek Ramaswamy is the favorite while former Ohio health director Amy Acton is the top Democratic contender.

May 16: Louisiana

Republican Sen. Bill Cassidy is facing a challenge from Rep. Julia Letlow, who **launched a primary bid** in January after receiving Trump's endorsement.

Cassidy has largely supported the president's second-term agenda but has voiced concerns about the administration's moves on vaccines and was one

of seven GOP senators who voted to convict Trump during his second impeachment trial in 2021 following the attack on the US Capitol. State Treasurer John Fleming and Public Service Commissioner Eric Skrmetta are also seeking the GOP nomination, while state Sen. Blake Miguez dropped his bid to run for Letlow's US House seat.

Louisiana's switch to a partisan primary system could also be a factor. If no candidate receives a majority of the primary vote, the top two finishers would advance to a June runoff.

May 19: Georgia and Kentucky

Georgia Republicans will pick a Senate nominee to challenge **Jon Ossoff**, the lone Senate Democrat seeking reelection this year in a state Trump won in 2024. A contest that will offer clues about the GOP's future direction features Reps. Buddy Carter and Mike Collins as well as former college football coach Derek Dooley, who is endorsed by Gov. Brian Kemp.

Both parties also have gubernatorial primaries in the race to succeed Kemp, who is term-limited. The Republican field includes Brad Raffensperger, the secretary of state who resisted Trump's pressure campaign to overturn the results of the 2020 election in Georgia, and Lt. Gov. Burt Jones, who served as a **fake elector seeking to falsely certify Trump** as the winner that year. Trump has endorsed Jones. State Attorney General Chris Carr and health care executive Rick Jackson are also running in the GOP primary, setting up the potential for a June runoff if no candidate wins a majority of the vote in May.

Democratic contenders include former Atlanta Mayor Keisha Lance Bottoms, former GOP Lt. Gov. Geoff Duncan and former state Sen. Jason Esteves.

Loyalty to Donald Trump and **the legacy of Mitch McConnell** are the political forces that have shaped the Republican Senate primary in Kentucky, where Rep. Andy Barr, former state Attorney General Daniel Cameron and businessman Nate Morris all have ties to the retiring GOP senator but have instead touted their pro-Trump credentials.

Kentucky Rep. Thomas Massie will also face Trump-backed primary challenger Ed Gallrein. The president's allies have made it a priority to knock out Massie as he's become a thorn in Trump's side on several issues, notably over **the release of the Jeffrey Epstein files**.

June 2: California and Iowa

There's a crowded field to replace California Gov. Gavin Newsom. Democratic candidates include former Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier Becerra, San Jose Mayor Matt Mahan, former Rep. Katie Porter, billionaire and climate activist Tom Steyer and former Los Angeles Mayor Antonio Villaraigosa. On the Republican side are Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco and conservative media personality Steve Hilton.

Rep. Eric Swalwell announced in April he would withdraw from the governor's race in the wake of **allegations of sexual misconduct**, which he has denied. The allegations sparked an unraveling of his campaign as staffers quit and prominent Democratic supporters urged him to end his bid.

Under California's primary system, all candidates run on the same primary ballot and the top two, regardless of party, advance to the general election.

Iowa could offer clues about whether Democrats are able to **make inroads** in more rural states. Democrat Rob Sand, the state auditor, is seeking to succeed outgoing GOP Gov. Kim Reynolds. The Republican field includes Rep. Randy Feenstra and farmer Zach Lahn.

The state also has an open Senate contest following GOP Sen. Joni Ernst's decision not to seek reelection, with Rep. Ashley Hinson the favorite on the Republican side. The Democratic primary features state Sen. Zach Wahls and state Rep. Josh Turek, a two-time Paralympic gold medalist in wheelchair basketball. Marine Corps veteran Nathan Sage exited the race in February and endorsed Turek.

June 9: Maine and South Carolina

Democrats are hoping that 2026 is the year they finally defeat Maine GOP Sen. Susan Collins, who has a proven track record of outperforming her party in the blue-leaning state. The question facing Democrats this year is whether Gov. Janet Mills, the favorite of the party establishment, or progressive Graham Platner, an oyster farmer and combat veteran, represent the best chance of accomplishing that goal.

Some in the party worry Platner's past controversial social media **posts** could jeopardize the party's chances against Collins, while others on the left see Mills – who would be the oldest freshman senator ever elected – as unlikely to excite base voters.

In South Carolina, the GOP primary for governor will be closely watched as a gauge of the mood of Republican voters in a key early state ahead of the 2028 nominating process. Lt. Gov. Pamela Evette, state Attorney General Alan Wilson and Reps. Nancy Mace and Ralph Norman are among the contenders to succeed Gov. Henry McMaster.

June 23: New York

Rep. Elise Stefanik's **decision** to end her gubernatorial bid left Nassau County Executive Bruce Blakeman as the sole major Republican vying to challenge Democratic Gov. Kathy Hochul, who is facing a primary from Lt. Gov. Antonio Delgado.

The star power in the Empire State may be in the 12th Congressional District, where a wide field is seeking to succeed longtime Rep. Jerry Nadler. The Democratic primary includes state assembly members Alex Bores and Micah Lasher, longtime Republican lawyer turned Trump critic George Conway and Jack Schlossberg, the grandson of former President John F. Kennedy.

July 21: Arizona

In Arizona, the GOP primary for governor features Reps. Andy Biggs and David Schweikert, who are vying for the opportunity to challenge Democratic Gov. Katie Hobbs in a crucial battleground state. Biggs is the lone candidate running with Trump's support after business executive Karrin Taylor Robson, who had also been endorsed by the president, ended her bid in February. By launching a run for governor, Schweikert opens up

a key House seat in November. The state moved its primaries earlier from August 4.

August 4: Michigan

Michigan is a state that has it all. There is an open race for governor that features rising stars in both parties: Secretary of State Jocelyn Benson on the Democratic side and Rep. John James on the Republican side. A potential wildcard in the race is Detroit Mayor Mike Duggan, who left the Democratic Party to run as an independent. Democratic Lt. Gov. Garlin Gilchrist ended his bid for governor in January and launched a run for secretary of state.

With Democrat Gary Peters retiring, the state also has an open Senate race that Democrats must hold if they stand a chance of winning the majority. The top contenders in that primary are Rep. Haley Stevens, seen as the favorite of the party establishment, state Sen. Mallory McMorrow, and Abdul El-Sayed, a progressive who is a former executive director of the Detroit Health Department. Former GOP Rep. Mike Rogers, who lost a 2024 bid for Senate against Democrat Elissa Slotkin, is running again.

August 11: Minnesota and Wisconsin

This day will serve up two big tests of the Democratic Party's direction with an ideological clash in the Minnesota Senate race and a wide-open contest for governor in Wisconsin.

In Minnesota, moderate Rep. Angie Craig and progressive Lt. Gov. Peggy Flanagan are facing off for the Democratic nomination and the chance to

succeed retiring Sen. Tina Smith. The GOP field includes **former sportscaster Michele Tafoya**. The state will also host an open race for governor after Democrat Tim Walz's decision not to seek reelection to a third term. Democratic Sen. Amy Klobuchar launched a bid in January, pledging to unify the state as it finds itself at the center of the Trump administration's immigration crackdown. GOP contenders include state House Speaker Lisa Demuth and MyPillow CEO Mike Lindell.